first thing the next morning. As soon as I finished lunch, I went straight to the PCO booth and called Hema.

‘Why are you staying there?’ Hema said when I told her I had reached IAM. ‘Come stay with us, at our place.’

‘No, no, I don’t want to trouble . . .’ But before I could finish, she barged in, ‘No, I won’t listen to anything. You have to come and stay with us.’

‘But is it even allowed?’ I asked her.

‘I’ll have Amma speak to the concerned officer,’ Hema said excitedly.

‘All right then, see you tomorrow,’ I said and hung up.

That evening I was told to fill up some papers regarding my medical history, which I then had to carry the next morning, before my medical tests. Spending the night in that big dorm room was made easy by the attendant, who kindly set up the common room’s television there for me to watch. As always, Bollywood songs lulled me to sleep.

The initial few medical tests, including a blood sample, blood-pressure check and other physical measurements and inspections, were over by noon, and I was free for the day. By this time, Hema’s mother had already asked the medical officer for his permission to allow me to stay with them. A willingness application filled out by me had to be submitted, which I did, after which I was allowed to go—on the condition that I would not be late for the tests the next day. I got free earlier than Hema’s mother, so I took the local bus for Jayanagar, the place where Hema stayed, not very far from the city centre. When I entered Jayanagar, I saw that unlike the commercial hub that Bangalore was, Jayanagar still maintained the old charm of the city. Apart from some shops, the place was mostly residential. I pushed open the bus’s window to let the soothing afternoon breeze in. I was excited to finally get to Hema’s house.

I got off the bus at the place Hema had told me to. Finding her house wasn’t difficult. Among the rows of all the other two-storey houses adjacent to a narrow street, numbered in ascending order, I found myself standing with my bag outside Hema’s house in no time. I rang the bell, wearing a huge smile on my face. No sooner had Hema opened the door than she